



Jewelry made of teeth of the great white shark, now protected in some areas

Oceans in peril

THE OCEANS AND THE LIFE THEY SUPPORT are under threat. Sewage and industrial waste are dumped into the oceans and poured from pipelines, carrying with them certain chemicals that can create a dangerous buildup in the food chain. Oil spills smother and poison marine life.

Garbagge dumped at sea can choke a turtle or trap a seabird. Many seabirds and sea mammals drown when caught in abandoned fishing nets. Overharvesting has depleted many ocean animals, from whales to fish. Even the souvenir trade threatens coral reefs. However, the situation is improving. Now, laws help stop ocean pollution, regulations protect marine life, and in underwater parks people can look at ocean life, but not disturb it.



Heart cockle shells

HAVE A HEART
Many people collect sea shells, because of their beauty, but most shells sold in stores have been taken as living animals, so if too many shelled creatures are collected from one place, such as a coral reef, the pattern of life can be disrupted. Shells should only be bought if the harvest is properly managed. It is better to go beachcombing and collect shells of already dead creatures. Always check about taking even empty shells, since some nature reserves do not permit this.



OIL SPILL

Oil is needed for industry and vehicles. Huge quantities are transported at sea in tankers, sent along pipelines, and brought up from the seabed. Accidents happen where massive amounts of oil are spilled. Seabirds and sea mammals die of the cold, because their feathers or fur no longer contain pockets of air to keep them warm. Trying to clean themselves, animals die from consuming the oil, which can block their airways. Some are rescued, cleaned, and released back into the wild.

SAVING BEAUTY

No one can help but admire this beautifully crafted, 17th-century, chambered nautilus shell. There are six kinds of nautilus living in the Pacific and Indian Oceans today, where they are at risk from overcollecting. They are easily hunted at night when they rise to the surface. Empty shells are collected because they can also float at the surface. Chambered nautilus grow quite slowly, reaching maturity in six or more years, so if too many are collected the populations can take a long time to recover.



Cut to show mother-of-pearl